

PALM

THE SCHOOL BUILDING

-A Report-

by

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A formal school building survey normally involves complex criteria and both extensive and intensive analyses of individual features of the many aspects of the building. A cursory tour, such as was conducted by me and others on May 24, 1968, normally would not be thought of as adequate for an evaluation of the Palm School building. However, the defects are of such a glaring nature there that even a cursory tour of the grounds and the building reveals them strikingly.

It is an undisputable fact that Palm should be replaced. It is also undisputable that the present site, unless enlarged by the purchase of the city property back of the school, is grossly inadequate. Further, I recommend the removal of the school, with new building, to a site not in such a hazardous and noisy area as at present -- i.e., East Avenue, First Street.

It seems almost unnecessary to list defects that are so completely obvious. To mention only a few:

1. The building is a "fire trap" -- wooden floors and walls, no adequate fire fighting provisions, etc.
2. No screens on second floor windows. A child could fall out.
3. The ground floor windows are protected by nailed down "hardware cloth" -- to keep the children from breaking window panes! Insects are not deterred, and children could not escape through the windows in case of fire.
4. The "portable" rooms, supposedly a very temporary emergency recourse, have become permanent annexes. Highly unsatisfactory from every point of view. The excuse that school moneys are needed for schools in newly expanded areas of the Austin Independent School District does not "hold water." Give those new areas the "portables" and give the long suffering (and long-paying) patrons of Palm the benefits of available funds first.

5. The promise (qualified) that Palm would be rebuilt an indefinite number of years from now is unacceptable. It should be rebuilt, on an adequate site, right now! This stole con el dedo ("gruel with the finger") business has thinned to extinction. The District is not poor or bankrupt. What it can afford elsewhere, it can afford at Palm. If more money is needed, tell the public and ask them to vote more money.

6. The testimony of school employees, and of former school employees, is unacceptable. They came up under the conditions protested by the citizens! So, they accept the situation as "not too bad." Their criteria, and/or their private concerns, are conditioned to the status quo.

7. I have a list of the obvious defects in the Palm building. But why list them? They are obvious. On an old Strayer-Englehart Score Card the school building would rate less than 400 on a 1,000 scale.

Like I stated at the meeting, patching up Palm School building is "throwing good money after bad."

Sincerely,

George I. Sánchez